

The music festival never really went away. Headliners may come and go, but music lovers will always yearn to retreat to an open field with their favourite band – and 100,000 other people [...].

The mythology of Woodstock

Woodstock wasn't by any means the only massive festival of its time, but it remains the touchstone. The mythology holds that Woodstock changed lives and transformed the world, and what promoter wouldn't want to claim that? Events such as the massive California Jam in April 1974 aimed to outdo Woodstock for cultural impact, or at least to make more money (and, in the latter case, easily succeeded).

And Apple co-founder Steve Wozniak's "US" Festivals of 1982-83 aimed to define their generation the way Woodstock had, pointing the way to a utopian high-tech future (the fest's name was meant to signal an end to the "me" generation). Whether they managed this is highly debatable, but at least The Police and Talking Heads played great sets.

The early 90s brought a resurgence of great bands at club level and a new culture around MTV, making the old days of crowding into a field look like old hat. But just when it seemed like the age of the festival might be winding down, along came Woodstock... again.

Woodstock for the MTV generation

[...] While Woodstock '69 was spiritually aligned with the anti-war movement, Woodstock '94 formally partnered with Greenpeace and identified corporate greed as the era's great injustice. Greenpeace set up an "Eco-Village" at the festival, demonstrating the potential of solar heating and recycling. But it also did something gutsier by pointing fingers directly at corporate offenders. In press releases before the fest, Greenpeace took aim at *Time* magazine for using polluting paper mills and even scolded the festival's own sponsor, Pepsi, accusing them of sending plastic bottles to Asian landfills rather than recycling them,

as the company claimed. This kind of activism would be incorporated into Lollapalooza and other fests to come. It was partly a nod to Woodstock's countercultural roots, but it also showed the influence of modern-day stars such as U2, Bruce Springsteen and R.E.M., who were all giving lobby space and onstage shout-outs to progressive organisations at their shows. [...]

Cynics at the time complained that Woodstock '94 would be a mere cash in, or that the crowds would get out of control. But that largely didn't happen – at least, not until they raised Woodstock one more time in 1999. For the time being, peace and love still ran the day and the two generations of concertgoers seemed fine with taking in each other's music – Bob Dylan and Traffic for the baby boomers, Metallica and Nine Inch Nails for Gen Xers, Peter Dinklage and Aerosmith for everybody. [...]

The first Lollapalooza

[...] While Lollapalooza became synonymous with "alternative" culture in the 90s, the definition was inclusive. There was always a metal band, a rap act and usually a trailblazing punk act (including Ramones, who delayed their break-up for a few months so they could do Lollapalooza in 1996). [...] But Lollapalooza wasn't just about the music: Farrell was sharp enough to recognise a certain edgy Generation X aesthetic, and worked out how to both reflect and market toward it. Lollapalooza was one of the first places where concertgoers discovered virtual-reality games, and we can only guess how many future tech leaders that inspired. [...] After a few on-and-off years, Lollapalooza remains a lucrative festival, happening in Chicago and internationally. But during the 90s it was a full-blown rite of passage.

➔ Brett Milano, *Woodstock and beyond: how the modern music festival came to be*, discovermusic.com, 2019

star performers in a show standard be better than
gathering more courageous innovative
the organiser

Read from l. 1 to 28. Pick out four characteristics of Woodstock and explain the aims of the two other festivals mentioned.

Read from l. 29 to 59. Show how Woodstock '94 was different from Woodstock '69 and present the initiatives taken at the festival.

Read from l. 60 to the end. Describe the particularities of Lollapalooza in your own words.

Compare the music festivals in the text. Say which one you like best and why.